The Election Administration and Voting Survey, 2024

A survey the country's election offices fill in about themselves, and the empty box that decides who can be compared

Democracy's Data

Last updated 31 August 2026

Americans say their elections are run by "the states," and the sentence is already wrong. Elections are run by 6,461 local offices — county clerks, township boards, city commissions, each receiving the ballots and deciding what to count. So who actually runs American elections, and what does the machinery report about itself? There is exactly one table in which every one of those offices answers the same questions in the same words. It exists because after every federal election, somebody in each office sits down with a questionnaire from Washington and starts filling in boxes.

Two of those boxes carry the stakes. Item C1b asks how many mail ballots came back; item C9a asks how many were rejected. Add C9a up across the country and the answer is 584,463 mail ballots that a voter filled in, sealed, and sent, and that were not counted — more people than live in Wyoming. A ballot that is cast and not counted is a distinct kind of failure. The voter did everything that was asked, the system did not complete the transaction, and in most states nobody is required to tell them.

This brief reads the questionnaire's answers for 2024. The finding runs in two layers. The machinery varies enormously — the same mailed ballot faces a many-fold difference in rejection risk from state to state. And the survey's own missing answers are not noise around that finding; in places they *are* the finding, deciding which states can be compared at all.

01 The test

The data is the **Election Administration and Voting Survey**: the U.S. Election Assistance Commission's census of every election office in the United States, taken after each federal election since 2004. This brief uses the 2024 edition, Version 2, released 12 February 2026 — Version 2 rather than Version 1, because the Commission corrected the first release and published an errata note saying what changed. The survey exists because the Help America Vote Act obliged the Commission to report on how federal election law works on the ground. Congress gave it no power to make any office answer accurately, or at all.

Why this source? Every other election dataset records the *output* of an election. Certified returns say who won and are permanently silent about the machinery that took the ballots in; the returns chapter sets out that limit. A rejected mail ballot leaves no trace in the returns, which count what was counted. Only a handful of states publish ballot-level rejection records, which is why the research literature leans so heavily on Florida and

North Carolina. The EAVS is the one table where all 56 states and territories answer the same question in the same words — the only service record American elections have.

The test is to compute the failure rates the survey supports: mail-ballot rejection nationally, by state, and by stated reason, with provisional-ballot rejection beside them. And it is to keep one eye on a second column the whole way — how many offices actually answered each item.

02 The data

The public release is a ZIP opening to a single CSV: 6,461 rows by 535 columns, one row per election office and one column per box on the form. Figure 1 is the form itself, at the two boxes everything below rests on.

Category of Mail Ballots	Total
C1a. TOTAL mail ballots transmitted: This number should include all mail ballots transmitted for the 2024 general election, including spoiled or replaced ballots or duplicate transmissions. *Do not include individuals who cast UOCAVA absentee ballots or individuals who used any form of in-person voting.*	
C1b. Returned by voters: Include ballots both counted and rejected and mail ballots that went through the curing process (if applicable in your state).	

Category of Mail Ballots	Total
C9a. TOTAL number of mail ballots rejected	
C9b. Ballot was not received on time/missed the deadline.	
C9c. Ballot did not have a voter signature.	
C9d. Ballot did not have a witness signature.	
C9e. Ballot had a non-matching or incomplete signature.	

Figure 1. The instrument. Items C1a and C1b from page 30 of the 2024 questionnaire, and items C9a to C9e from page 34, as the Commission publishes them. C1b, mail ballots returned, is the denominator of every rejection rate below: the bottom number of the fraction, what you are dividing by. C9a is the numerator, the top number. They are separate boxes, filled in by separate acts of clerical attention, and nothing on the form requires either one.

Here are three rows, sliced to six of the 535 columns:

FIPSCode	Jurisdiction_Name	…	State_Abbr	…	C1a	C1b	…	C9a	…
0100100000	AUTAUGA COUNTY	…	AL	…	1822	-99	…	14	…
0100300000	BALDWIN COUNTY	…	AL	…	8902	-99	…	187	…
1314500000	HARRIS COUNTY	…	GA	…	1153	1037	…	10	…

Read the Autauga row as arithmetic and it says the county sent 1,822 mail ballots, got back minus ninety-nine of them, and rejected 14. **The −99 is not a number.** It is the survey's code for "did not answer," and −88 means "the question does not apply"; both sit in the same numeric columns as the counts. The file also carries line breaks inside its free-text comment fields, so counting lines says it holds seventeen thousand records when parsing it properly finds 6,461.

Four cleaning decisions produce the tables this brief reads. Negative codes become missing, never zero — turned into zero they would silently deflate every total. The numerator and denominator of each rate are counted separately, because the offices answering C1b and C9a are not the same set. Rows are rolled up to states, since the file's row is an office and the questions worth asking are about states and the country. And nothing is dropped for looking wrong: an office reporting more rejections than returns keeps its row, because no independent record exists to correct it against.

What a row *is* also moves under you:

State	Jurisdictions	Registered voters	Voters per jurisdiction
VT	247	361,604	1,464
ME	497	842,447	1,695
WI	1851	3,434,185	1,855
DC	1	328,871	328,871
AK	1	340,981	340,981
PR	1	1,283,628	1,283,628

Wisconsin reports 1,851 jurisdictions and Texas 254, because Wisconsin runs elections through townships and Texas through counties. A typical Vermont jurisdiction serves about 1,464 voters and a typical California one about 278,695. So anything averaged over rows, across states, compares things that are not the same kind of thing; totals and rates are safe, and "the average jurisdiction" is not.

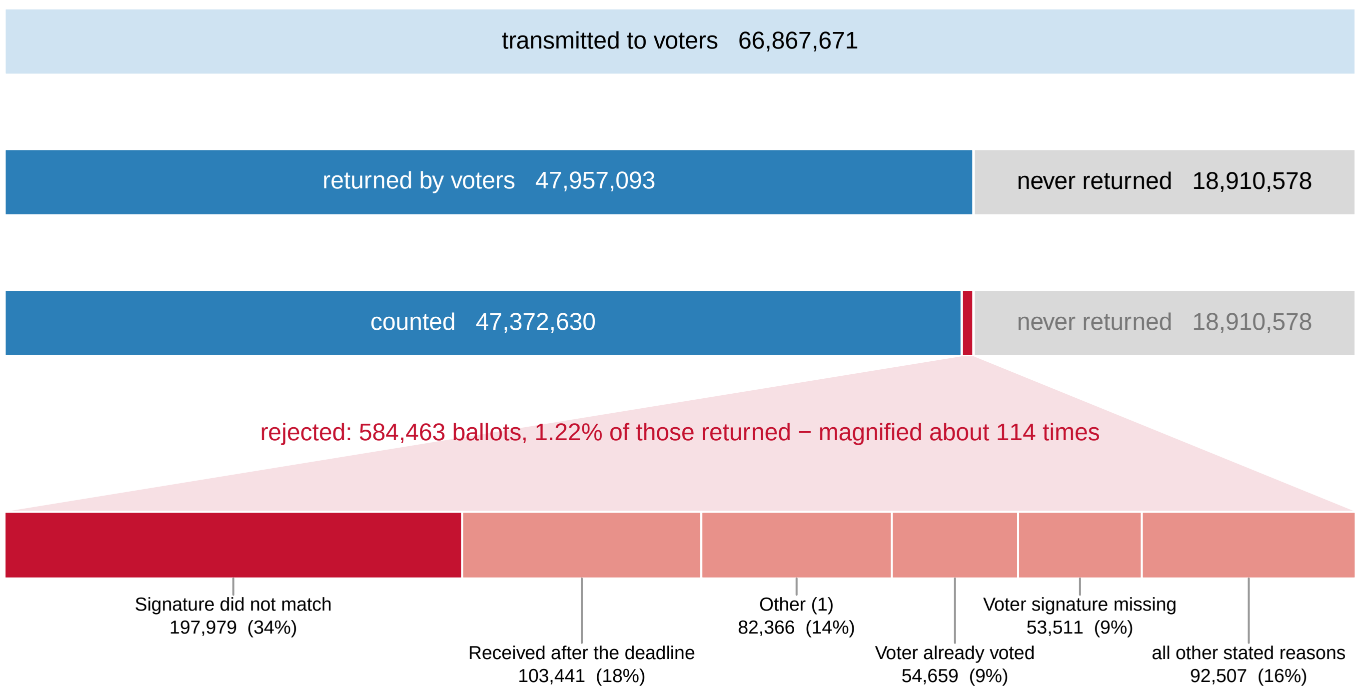
The derived tables are four. `national.csv` holds each headline item's `total`, the count of jurisdictions it was `reported_by`, and `pct_reporting`. `states.csv` holds one row per state: `jurisdictions`, `voters`, `mail_sent`, `mail_returned`, `mail_rejected`, `prov_cast`, `prov_rejected`. `reasons.csv` breaks rejected mail ballots down by the `reason` recorded, with `ballots`, `reported_by`, and `pct_of_rejected`. `units.csv` carries `voters_per_jurisdiction` by state.

> **Before you read on, answer yes or no.** Every rejection rate below is *rejected ÷ returned*: two survey items, with two different response rates. Missing data usually scatters an estimate — some rates too high, some too low, no particular direction. **Does it here?** Write down yes or no, and if no, write down which way it pushes.

03 What it says about democracy

Item	National total	Jurisdictions reporting it	% reporting
Total voters	158,211,780	6,449	99.8
Total precincts	177,708	6,451	99.8
Mail ballots transmitted to voters	66,867,671	6,445	99.8
Mail ballots returned by voters	47,957,093	6,131	94.9
Mail ballots returned undeliverable	932,533	5,843	90.4
Mail ballots rejected	584,463	6,361	98.5
Provisional ballots cast	1,736,209	5,654	87.5
Provisional ballots counted in full	1,199,465	5,621	87.0
Provisional ballots rejected	436,258	5,162	79.9

158,211,780 registered voters, 177,708 precincts, 66,867,671 mail ballots sent out. The two right-hand columns are the ones coverage never quotes: no item is answered by everyone, and provisional-ballot rejections come from 79.9% of offices. **Every national total in this table is a floor**, and the gap between the floor and the truth is unknowable from this file.



Widths are exact shares of the 66,867,671 ballots transmitted. Every total is a floor: the four items come from between 80% and 100% of jurisdictions.

Figure 2. What happens to a mail ballot, drawn to one scale, with the failure magnified. Widths are exact shares of the 66,867,671 ballots transmitted, because the point is proportion. The 584,463 rejected ballots are a sliver, 1.22% of the 47,957,093 returned, and the sliver has to be blown up about 114 times before anyone can see inside it. The bottom bar splits it by the reason recorded, largest first: **Signature did not match** alone accounts for 34% of every mail ballot rejected in the country.

The national 1.22% is the number most often quoted, and it hides the actual finding. Do the same arithmetic state by state, among the 40 states that handled more than 100,000 returned mail ballots:

State	Mail ballots returned	Rejected	Rate (%)
OK	103,025	4,477	4.35
TX	398,270	14,049	3.53
KY	120,400	4,076	3.39
MI	2,081,265	63,561	3.05
NY	862,737	25,750	2.98
VT	237,565	467	0.20
IN	1,607,247	3,432	0.21
ME	215,753	511	0.24
MD	747,040	2,796	0.37

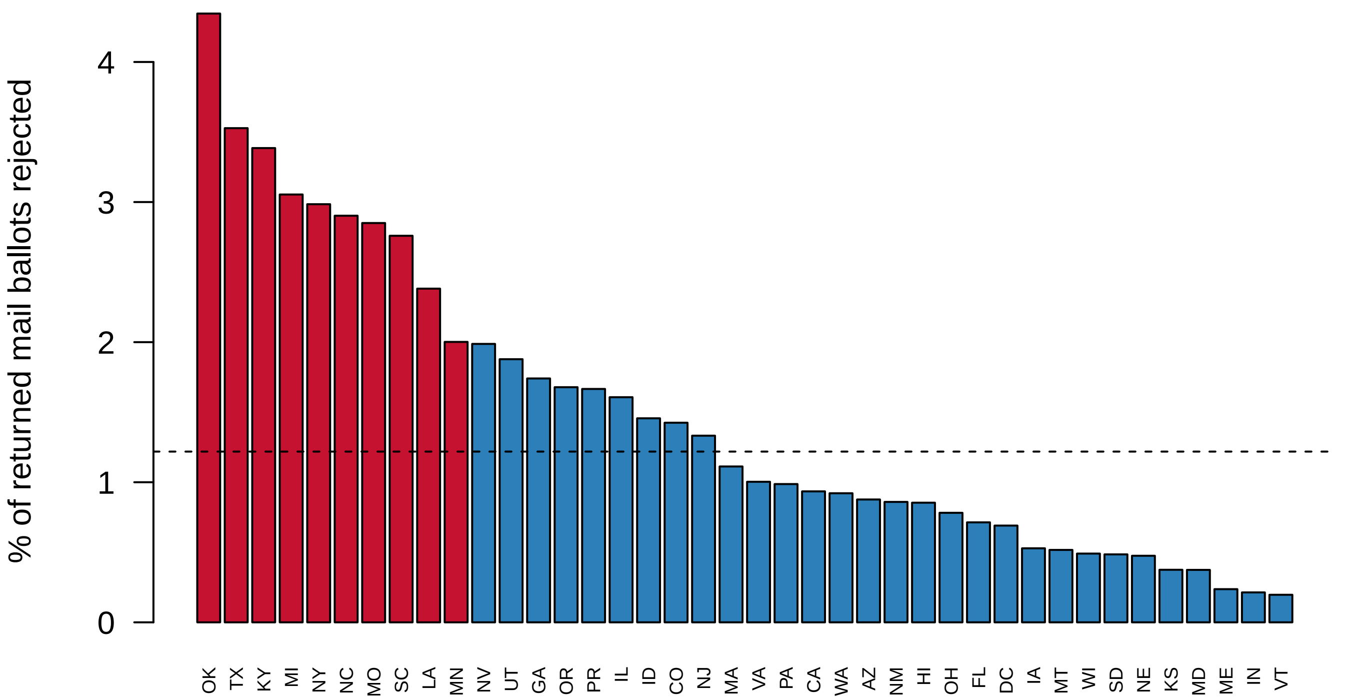


Figure 3. The chance that a mailed ballot is thrown away, by state. The 40 states handling more than 100,000 returned mail ballots, ranked by the share rejected; the dashed line is the national 1.22%. Oklahoma sits at 4.35% and Vermont at 0.20%, a 22-fold difference in the same act performed in two states.

That spread is not voters behaving differently in Oklahoma. It is rules — witness requirements, signature matching, postmark deadlines, and above all whether the state lets a voter fix a problem after the fact. Baringer, Herron and Smith (2020), reading Florida's ballot-level records, found rejection concentrated among younger voters, voters outside the major parties, and first-time mail voters. A procedural failure that lands harder on particular people is a franchise problem, not a clerical one.

Now the answer to the prompt. **No** — and most readers write yes, because scattering is what missing data usually does. This missing data pushes in one direction, and then it removes whole states from the comparison.

Item	Jurisdictions	% of the country
Mail ballots rejected (C9a) — the numerator	6,361	98.5%
Mail ballots returned (C1b) — the denominator	6,131	94.9%
Jurisdictions reporting a rejection count but no returned count	230	3.6%

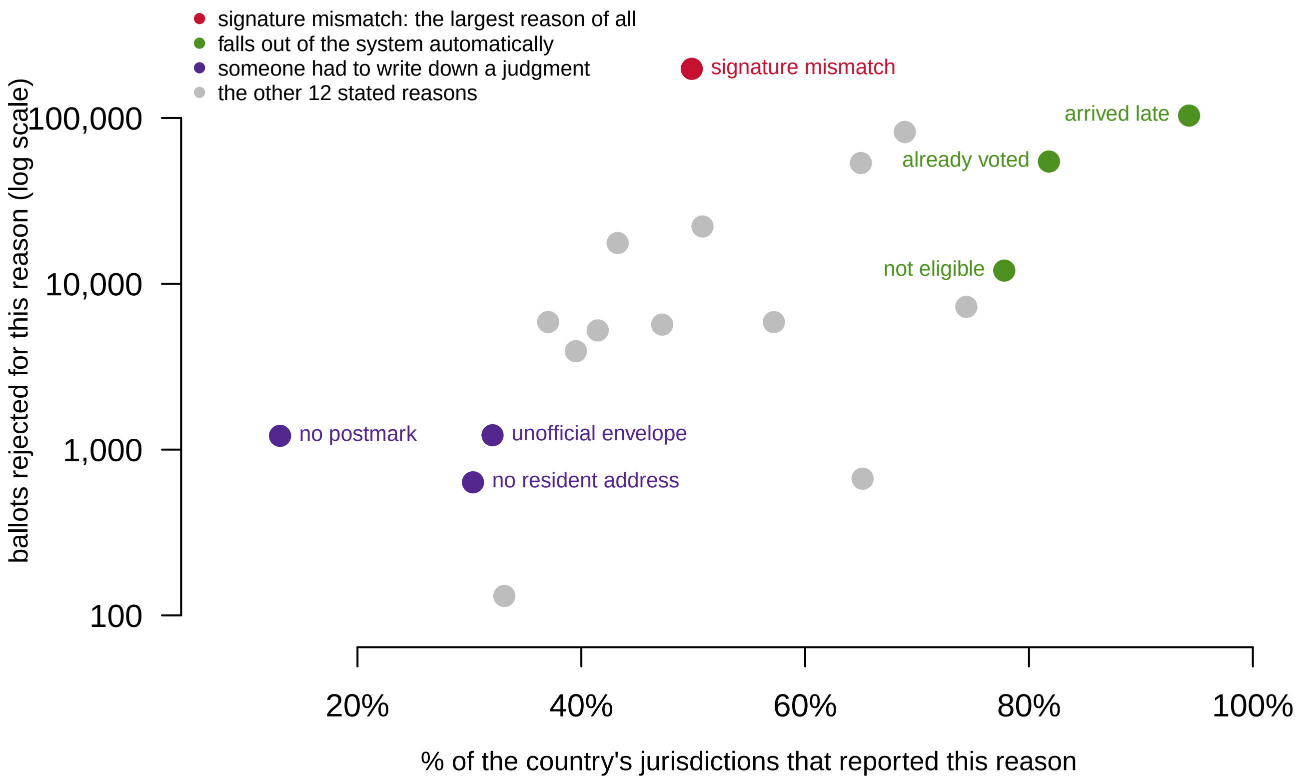
The denominator is measured worse than the numerator: 230 offices told the Commission how many ballots they rejected and not how many came back. Wherever that happens the denominator is short and the rate is too high, in one direction only. At state level it stops being subtle:

State	Registered voters	Mail ballots sent	Returned	Rejected
AL	2,272,911	140,558	0	1,779
CT	1,820,891	129,996	0	2,642
MP	12,610	1,168	0	13
MS	1,225,176	28,558	0	0

4 states and territories report sending and rejecting mail ballots while reporting that zero came back. Alabama sent 140,558 and rejected 1,779 of the none that returned. No rate can be computed from that, so Alabama is not at the top of Figure 3 or the bottom. It is not in the figure at all. The file does not flag this or carry a warning; a zero and a missing value look identical in a spreadsheet, and only arithmetic that cannot work reveals which one you are holding. The non-response does not blur the ranking — it silently decides who is eligible to be ranked.

The reasons column carries the same lesson in a finer grain:

Reason recorded	Ballots	% of all rejections
Signature did not match	197,979	33.9
Received after the deadline	103,441	17.7
Other (1)	82,366	14.1
Voter already voted	54,659	9.4
Voter signature missing	53,511	9.2
Missing documentation	22,175	3.8



The three automatic reasons are reported by 85% of jurisdictions on average; the three judgment reasons by 25%.
Signature mismatch, the largest category of all, sits at 50%. The gray dots are the remaining 12 reasons, named in the table above.

Figure 4. How many ballots each reason accounts for, against how well it is known. A scatter, because the finding is the relationship between two columns of `reasons.csv`. Up the page is ballots rejected for that reason, on a log scale; across is the share of the country's 6,461 jurisdictions reporting it. The three reasons an office's systems record automatically are reported by 85% of jurisdictions on average; the three that need a person to write down a judgment, by 25%. Signature mismatch, the largest category of all at 197,979 ballots, is reported by 50% — we know least about the reason where human discretion matters most.

One more failure is larger and less discussed. A provisional ballot is the safety net for a voter who turns up and something is wrong — not on the list, wrong ID, wrong place.

Quantity	Value
Provisional ballots cast	1,736,209
Counted in full	1,199,465
Rejected	436,258
Rejection rate	25.1%
Reported by	79.9% of jurisdictions

About one provisional ballot in four is rejected, against 1.22% of returned mail ballots — and the count comes from the worst-covered item in the whole survey, so the real figure is larger.

04 What this brief cannot tell you

It cannot say whether a high-rejection state is strict or careless. A state that verifies signatures will reject more ballots than one that does not, and that could be integrity working or suppression operating. Both readings produce the same row; telling them apart needs the fifty-one rulebooks, which are not in this file.

It cannot say who was rejected. There are no demographics anywhere in the survey. The file counts ballots, not people, which is why the who-gets-rejected findings come from the few states publishing ballot-level records.

It cannot audit itself. Every number is a self-report by the office being measured, gathered under a mandate to publish rather than a mandate to comply. No independent record exists to check most answers against.

And it cannot arrive in time. The survey covering an election appears more than a year later, so the country receives its election's service record after the argument about that election is over.

05 What you should have learned

- American elections are run by 6,461 local offices, and the EAVS is the one table where all of them answer the same questions — 584,463 mail ballots and 436,258 provisional ballots rejected in 2024.
- The same mailed ballot faces very different risks by state: 4.35% rejected in Oklahoma against 0.20% in Vermont, a 22-fold gap that reflects rules, not voters.
- No survey item is answered by every office, so every national total is a floor; the worst-covered headline item reaches 79.9% of jurisdictions.
- The missingness is directional: 230 offices reported rejections without returns, biasing rates upward, and 4 states drop out of the ranking entirely by reporting zero where they mean "not reported."
- The largest stated reason for rejection is a signature judged not to match — 33.9% of all rejections — and it is among the worst-reported reasons in the file.

06 Extensions

None of these is answered above, and every one can be answered from the tables the Sources section hands over.

- `national.csv` reports `pct_reporting` for every item. Sort by it. Which questions do election offices reliably answer, and what do the skipped ones have in common?
- `units.csv` gives `voters_per_jurisdiction` by state. Compare the extremes. Does "a jurisdiction" mean the same thing in any two states you pick?
- `reasons.csv` has `ballots` and `reported_by` side by side. Compute each reason's share of 6,461 jurisdictions reporting. Which reasons are about the voter, and which are about the system?
- `states.csv` has `prov_cast` and `prov_rejected`. Compute provisional rejection rates and rank them. Is the spread wider or narrower than for mail?

Two stretch ideas point past the spreadsheet. The Commission publishes the 2022 and 2020 surveys at the same address. Fetch one and check whether the states at the top of Figure 3 stay at the top, which is what a rules explanation predicts. And look up whether each of your top five states offers a cure process, a chance to fix a rejected envelope, and decide how far that one rule goes toward explaining the ranking.

07 Sources

Data

- U.S. Election Assistance Commission, *Election Administration and Voting Survey, 2024*, Version 2 — 6,461 jurisdictions, 535 columns, with the official codebook. Version 2 rather than Version 1: V1 was corrected, and the EAC publishes an errata note listing what changed. https://www.eac.gov/research-and-data/datasets-codebooks-and-surveys
- The form in Figure 1 is the EAC's own **2024 EAVS questionnaire**, cropped to items C1a/C1b and C9a–C9e, retrieved 10 August 2026 and reproduced here so this document needs no network to read. https://www.eac.gov/sites/default/files/2024-04/2024_EAVS_FINAL_508c.pdf

Academic literature

- Baringer, A., Herron, M. C. and Smith, D. A. (2020). "Voting by Mail and Ballot Rejection: Lessons from Florida for Elections in the Age of the Coronavirus." *Election Law Journal* 19(3): 289–320.
- Merivaki, T. and Smith, D. A. (2020). "A Failsafe for Voters? Cast and Rejected Provisional Ballots in North Carolina." *Political Research Quarterly* 73(1): 65–78.
- Hasen, R. L. (2020). *Election Meltdown: Dirty Tricks, Distrust, and the Threat to American Democracy.* Yale University Press.
- Burden, B. C. and Stewart, C. III, eds. (2014). *The Measure of American Elections.* Cambridge University Press.

The data itself

Every figure above is drawn from these tables. They are plain CSV, they open in a spreadsheet, and they are yours to take further.

`national.csv`, `reasons.csv`, `states.csv`, `units.csv`

REBUILD THIS DATA YOURSELF, WITH AN AI ASSISTANT

```
I want to rebuild a public dataset from its original source, without
any starting files. Please do the following and show your work.
THE SOURCE. U.S. Election Assistance Commission, Election
Administration and Voting Survey, 2024, public release Version 2:
https://www.eac.gov/sites/default/files/2026-
02/2024_EAVS_for_Public_Release_nolabel_V2_csv.zip
A zip of about 2 MB expanding to a 41 MB CSV. One row is one local
```

election jurisdiction – a county in most states, a township in New England, Wisconsin and Michigan – and there are 6,461 of them, with 535 columns each. No account or key is needed. Use Version 2, not the original release: the first version was corrected, and an errata note on the same site lists what changed.

Three traps in the file itself. Missing answers are coded –99 and not-applicable items –88, so summing a raw column mixes real counts with negative codes; drop the negatives before any total. Comment fields contain line breaks, so counting lines says the file is far longer than its actual rows; a real CSV parser gets it right. And a ”jurisdiction” is not one kind of thing, so any per-jurisdiction average compares townships to counties.

WHAT TO BUILD.

1. National totals for the headline items – registered voters, precincts, mail ballots sent, returned, and rejected, provisional ballots cast – each with the number of jurisdictions that actually reported it, since no item is reported by everyone.
2. Jurisdictions per state, showing the unit-of-observation problem.

CHECK YOUR WORK. The copy this book used was fetched in August 2026. If your rebuild matches it, you should find:

- 6,461 jurisdictions and 535 columns
- 158,211,780 registered voters, reported by 6,449 jurisdictions
- 584,463 mail ballots rejected, and 177,708 precincts
- Wisconsin reports 1,851 jurisdictions; Texas reports 254

The survey runs every two years and this edition has already been revised once; a further revision would move the numbers because the EAC corrected them, not because you made an error.